

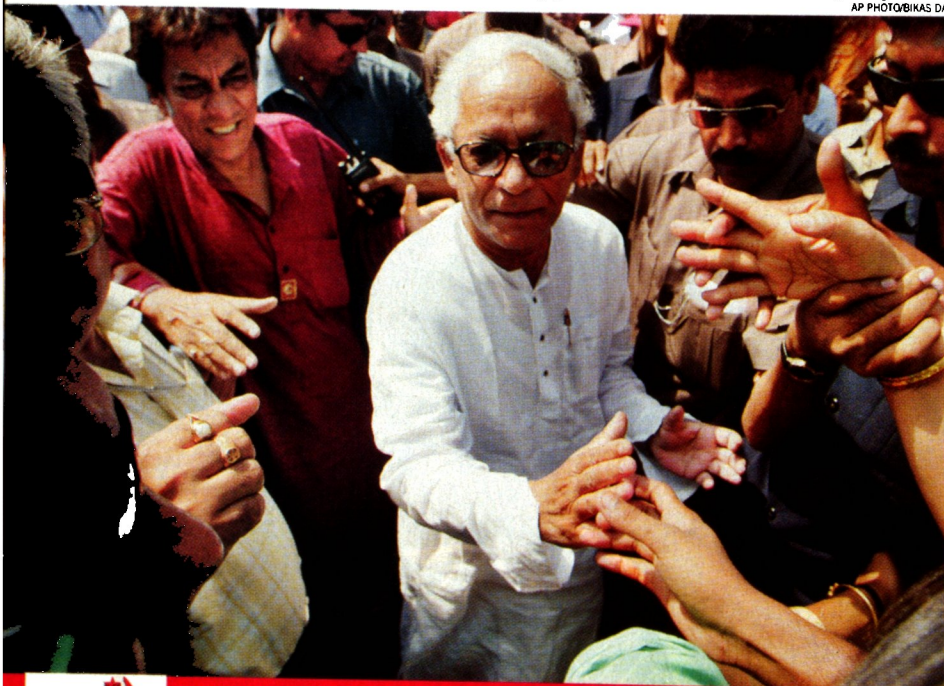
Left Front for the last 30 years in West Bengal. Now they appear disillusioned. This is an unhealthy sign for Left politics in India. The Congress is caught in a cleft stick. Even its criticism of Nandigram has been done with kidgloves. The tone was set at the AICC session in Delhi where the party's political resolution mentioned Nandigram in a stand alone paragraph, according to the same status as Naxalite violence. "The AICC notes with grave concern the situation in Nandigram where the writ of the state Government appears to have ceased to

their speeches at the AICC session.

The BJP, on its part, is trying to link Nandigram to the Left's sudden change of heart on the nuclear deal despite the fact that both Prakash Karat and Sitaram Yechury have denied this. Regardless, it was amidst the Nandigram flare-up that the Left inexplicably okayed the negotiations with the IAEA after opposing the step for the last three months. The BJP has demanded that the Centre impose Article 355 in the state and is delighted that it has such a live issue to attack the UPA with on the eve of Gujarat elections.

**HEMMED IN: Buddhadeb is increasingly isolated within his own party**

AP PHOTO/BIKAS DAS



steps to encourage investments. Trade unions here are responsible. In all, the perfect scenario for investing."

Apart from industrialists, Buddhadeb's best bet is that he is still first among equals. As author Gangopadhyaya says, "One can't deny that the present government has a lot of flaws. The Left has ruled for years. And as they say, absolute power corrupts absolutely. But, then again, if we get rid of this government, who will come to power? I can't see any responsible leaders on the horizon. If this government goes, the rate of growth of the state will nosedive. Let this government reform itself.

That, of course, will be the key to Buddhadeb's continuance in the chief minister's chair. His mentor Jyoti Basu, having handpicked him for the post, is unlikely to turn against him. The Marxists are traditionally wary of change, specially change in leadership, no matter what the provocation. Jyoti Basu, as India's longest reigning chief minister, is testimony to that. Buddhadeb is 63, young by Marxist standards, and has just started another term as chief minister. The middle class is disillusioned but have not abandoned him altogether.

He is clearly a man under serious pressure, from within his party, and from the minorities, increasingly farmers, intellectuals and political parties like the Trinamool Congress, sections of the Congress, the BJP and -



**FROM THE DARLING of the masses, Buddhadeb is now a pale shadow of his former self. His rush to transform and reform has pushed him against the wall.**

run," stated the resolution.

This is probably the strongest condemnation of a UPA ally made at the Central level by the Congress. A gleeful Dasmunshi, who had until then single-handedly been taking on the CPI(M) over Nandigram, felt vindicated. He had reason to. It was at his instance that the Congress had included the paragraph on Nandigram while the other Congressman from West Bengal, the more pragmatic External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee had been arguing against it, citing coalition compulsions. However, both Sonia Gandhi and the prime minister refrained from raising Nandigram in

Conscious of the fact that it still needs the Left Front's support to stay in power, the UPA Government is adopting a wait and watch policy. Interestingly, apart from the Congress, the rest of the UPA allies have been low key in their condemnation of the Marxists.

That should give Buddhadeb some breathing space. In fact, his increasing isolation is tempered by the fact that the industry remains solidly behind him. He has already garnered Rs 3,500 crore worth of investments in the last year alone. Says Sanjeev Goenka, vice-president of RPG Enterprises, "The labour here is qualified. The state Government is pro-actively taking

outfits with dubious political connections like the ones responsible for Black Wednesday in Kolkata.

From the darling of the masses, Buddhadeb is now a pale shadow of his former self. His critics in the party call him 'Gorbachev' Bhattacharjee, a reference to the similarities between him and the former Soviet leader who introduced unprecedented reforms in communist thinking. For Buddhadeb, the worry is that he could follow Gorbachev in another area he is more famous for—overseeing the disintegration of the mighty Soviet empire.

**with Sanjay Bhadra, Rabishankar Dutta, Satarupa Bhattacharya, Priya Sahgal**